

2c. Content of unit group 2: Non-British period study (Units Y201 to Y224)

Introduction to unit group 2

Centres should choose one of the twenty-four units available in this unit group.

The periods of non-British study will have the same number of Key Topics as for the British Period Study element, but there is no associated Enquiry element.

For the assessment of this unit group, each unit will have two questions set and learners will answer both parts from one of the questions. Learners will be required to answer both a traditional 'Period Study' essay (as in a unit group 1) and a shorter question assessing the significance of two events, pertaining to a different key topic from within the option chosen.

The nature of both questions ensures that learners will have to reach a supported judgement if they want to access the higher mark range.

The length of the periods studied within this unit group will encourage learners to develop their interest in, and understanding of, important developments. They will also enable learners to ask significant questions about important issues. They are sufficiently broad and balanced to ensure both coherence and variety. The units have sufficient chronological range to provide for the study of continuity and change, which will allow the development of the Key Topics and for the analysis of cause and consequences within the periods. The length of periods studied will prevent a borehole

approach to their study and learners will be able to see change and developments, and make substantiated judgements, over substantial lengths of time, so that they can see issues in a wider perspective. The topic areas available in the units in this group also include the study of significant individuals, societies, events and issues. They also include a range of different historical perspectives, for example aesthetic, cultural, economic, ethnic, political, religious, scientific, social and technological.

Centres will be able to choose, should they desire, a non-European period from the same time period as their British unit and this will also allow a broad understanding of the period in a wider context.

The nature of the examination will require learners to demonstrate an understanding of the key historical terms and concepts relevant to the period studied. The questions will require learners to recall, select and deploy appropriate knowledge and communicate this clearly and effectively. Learners will be expected to demonstrate abilities to explain, assess, analyse and consider the relationships between key features of the period studied in order to reach substantiated judgements. All responses will require judgements, and at the top level will be more analytical with judgements more effectively substantiated than similar question set at AS Level. This is ensured by a more demanding top level to the generic mark scheme.

Key Topics	Content Learners should have studied the following:
The Middle East c.550–620	The structure of pre-Islamic Arabia in the mid 6 th Century, economic and social issues; religious beliefs in pre-Islamic Arabia; the commercial importance of Mecca; the influence of tribalism; the decline of the Byzantine and the Sassanian Empires and the impact on the Arab world; the impact of plague and warfare; Arab military strengths; the Meccan period c.570–620.
The establishment of Islam c.620–632	The impact of Revelation and the hijra; the Medinan period c.622–632; challenges to the Prophet Muhammad; the flight of the Prophet Muhammad; the Constitution of Medina and its significance; the early growth of Islam and reasons for its appeal, the economy and its role in the rise of Islam.
The beginning of the Empire and the rule of the 'Rightly Guided Caliphs'	Disagreements about the succession; the succession of Abu Bakr (632); the Ridda Wars of Wars of Apostasy (632–633); the beginnings of the Empire and expansion into Persia, reasons for success; the rule of Abu Bakr (632–634), his emergence as Caliph, the nature of his rule and achievements; Umar ibn al-Khattab (634–644), the reasons for his rise, expansion and the governance of conquered lands, the treatment of non-Muslims, the fall of Damascus and Jerusalem (637); Uthman ibn Affan (644–656), early successes, growing internal problems, rebellion and the murder of Uthman; Ali ibn Abi Talib (656–661), opposition and arbitration.
The establishment and expansion of the Umayyad Empire	The rule of Mu'awiya (661–680), problems and achievements, succession crisis; the Second Fitna of 680; the rule of 'Abd al-Malik (685–705); the establishment of Syria and Damascus; expansion of the Empire in North Africa, Spain, the Middle East and Sindh and Punjab; relations with Christians; systems and methods of government; unrest, including the Third Fitna; decline of the Umayyad Empire.